

/etc/selinux/config — Quick Reference

Explanation of each directive that controls SELinux on the system

Purpose of the file

This file sets how SELinux behaves at boot: whether its security policy is fully enforced, only logged as warnings, or not loaded at all — plus which policy “type” (rule set) is used.

SELINUX= (the mode)

enforcing	SELinux policy is actively applied. Any action that violates policy is blocked and logged. This is the secure, production-recommended setting.
permissive	SELinux policy is NOT enforced, but violations are still logged as warnings. Useful for testing/debugging policy without breaking anything.
disabled	No SELinux policy is loaded at all. The system runs without any SELinux protection or logging.

Important note on "disabled"

On newer Fedora kernels, setting SELINUX=disabled here no longer fully disables SELinux at boot — the kernel may still load with no policy. To truly disable SELinux from boot, pass selinux=0 on the kernel command line, e.g.:

grubby --update-kernel ALL --args selinux=0

To re-enable SELinux later, remove that argument:

grubby --update-kernel ALL --remove-args selinux

SELINUXTYPE= (the policy set)

targeted	Only specific (targeted) processes/daemons are confined and protected by SELinux; everything else runs unconfined. This is the common default.
minimum	A modified/reduced version of the targeted policy — only selected processes are protected, even fewer than 'targeted'.
mls	Multi-Level Security. Enforces strict, military-style data classification/clearance levels. Most restrictive and complex option.

In this file: SELINUX=enforcing and SELINUXTYPE=targeted — the system actively enforces SELinux policy, protecting only the targeted set of processes/daemons.